

THE AIR POLLUTION CHALLENGE



1.36–3.3%
OF INDIA'S GDP

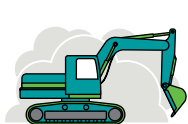
VARIED ESTIMATES OF
ECONOMIC LOSSES
TO INDIA'S GDP FROM
AIR POLLUTION



1.7 MILLION
DEATHS

LINKED TO ANTHROPOGENIC
PM2.5 EXPOSURE IN 2022, AS
PER THE LANCET
COUNTDOWN ON HEALTH AND
CLIMATE CHANGE 2025

MAJOR CONTRIBUTORS TO PM10 CONCENTRATIONS



14%–58%
ROAD DUST AND
CONSTRUCTION
ACTIVITIES



10%–33%
VEHICULAR
EMISSIONS



8%–34%
INDUSTRIAL
SOURCES



8%–29%
WASTE/
BIOMASS
BURNING

SOURCE APPORTIONMENT STUDIES IN 90 CITIES UNDER
NATIONAL CLEAN AIR PROGRAMME

FOR CLEAR, BLUE SKIES

- Need for concerted measures across sectors and states to tackle air pollution
- Robust and real-time monitoring to take pollution control measures in advance
- Fiscal measures and grants tied to PM reduction targets mooted
- Reduction in use of fossil fuels in kitchens and industries
- Better livestock and crop waste management

WHAT'S BEING DONE

- National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) in 2019 for 130 cities
- Under the 15th FC, air quality performance grant of ₹16,539 crore to 42 cities with million+ people
- Real-time monitoring of air quality
- Subsidies to consumers for EV cars, solar panels
- Curbs on construction, industrial activities during peak pollution
- Restrictions on burning of crop residue

when selecting locations for expansion, particularly for service sector companies such as those in tourism or IT. Attracting and retaining talent, especially for new-age companies, can be difficult as air quality is an important concern now, she says.

Pradeep Singhvi, Executive Director, Energy and Climate Practice, Grant Thornton Bharat, concurs and points out that Gurugram—the start-up hub of the north—has seen many start-ups move or expand to other cities due to air quality. “Many multinational corporations are increasingly favouring cities such as Hyderabad over highly polluted regions like Delhi NCR, recognising that air quality has a direct bearing on workforce health, productivity, and talent retention,” he says.

A CALL FOR ACTION

While the Centre and states have taken measures to improve air quality and there has been some reduction in PM 2.5 concentration, we need to do much more. Air purifiers, sales of which see a sharp spike during smog season, can be afforded only by middle- and upper-income categories. Even that is not a sustainable solution.

Mumbai's Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation has also started enforcing pollution control measures. The city has deployed electric buses and checked construction activities to mitigate outdoor dust.

Companies too are taking stock of what can be done. Arora helped set up the India CEO Forum on Clean Air—an industry platform anchored at CII. Started in 2019 with just 17 members, it has 136 members today and works with subnational governments, urban local bodies, start-ups and